

Discovering Aarhus, Denmark : Version 1

Welcome to Aarhus, one of Denmark's historic cities, where medieval churches, Viking history, and modern Danish life come together. This tour will take you through three fascinating places: Aarhus Cathedral, Our Lady Church (Vor Frue Kirke), and the Viking Museum.

Stop 1: Aarhus Cathedral — The Heart of Medieval Aarhus

"Good morning, ladies and gentlemen! Welcome to our first destination, Aarhus Cathedral, also known as Aarhus Domkirke.

Please take a moment to look at this magnificent building. Imagine standing here several hundred years ago, when this church was one of the most important buildings in the city.

My dear visitors, have you ever wondered what a city looked like before modern buildings, cars, and electric lights? In medieval times, a church like this was much more than a place of worship. It was a centre of community life, an important landmark, and a symbol of faith.

Construction of Aarhus Cathedral began in the late 12th century under Bishop Peder Vognsen. The building developed over several centuries, and major Gothic rebuilding took place between approximately 1449 and 1500. Today, it measures about 93 metres long, making it Denmark's longest church.

The story of Saint Clement

"Now, let me share a little story behind the name of this cathedral.

The church is dedicated to Saint Clement, who is traditionally regarded as the patron saint of sailors. According to Christian tradition, Clement was martyred by drowning with an anchor attached to him.

Why might this be meaningful in Aarhus?

Aarhus has a long connection with the sea, trade, and travel. For a city whose life has been linked to its harbour, a patron saint associated with sailors would have had particular significance.

Imagine the sailors of the past preparing for a dangerous journey across the sea. Before leaving, they might have prayed for protection and hoped to return safely to their families. We can use this image to understand how religion and everyday life were connected in medieval communities."

Architecture and art

"Now, if you look at the building, you can see its impressive brick construction and tall Gothic features.

Inside, one of the most interesting things to notice is the collection of medieval frescoes, or wall paintings. These paintings were created mainly between the late 15th and early 16th centuries. Before the Reformation, many church interiors were decorated with religious images that helped communicate biblical stories to people who could not read.

Let's walk down the center aisle. Look at the walls and the ceiling vaults. Do you see all those colourful paintings? Those are **medieval frescoes** dating from the 14th and 15th centuries. During the Protestant Reformation in 1536, when Denmark turned Lutheran, these paintings were seen as too Catholic and were completely covered in white plaster. Ironically, that plaster preserved them perfectly for centuries until they were uncovered and restored in the 1900s!

As you explore the interior, look for the paintings and notice how the artists used colour, figures, and symbols to tell stories.

I would also encourage you to look up at the high vaulted ceilings. Imagine the skill and patience required to construct such a large building without the machinery available to modern builders."

Before we move on, look up at the ceiling of the nave to spot a surprising piece of decor: a large, fully-rigged model warship hanging from the rafters. It was built in Holland in the 1700s, allegedly intended as a gift for Russian Tsar Peter the Great. However, the ship carrying it wrecked off the Danish coast. The model was salvaged by locals and gifted to the cathedral as a votive offering for sailors.

Please remember that this is an active place of worship, so we should speak quietly and respect anyone who is praying. If photography is permitted during your visit, please follow the church's current rules.



The Altar Piece

"Ladies and gentlemen, please direct your attention to the magnificent altarpiece in front of us.

This is one of the most remarkable treasures of Aarhus Cathedral. It was inaugurated in 1479, more than 500 years ago, and was created in the workshop of Bernt Notke, a famous master craftsman from Lübeck, Germany.

Just imagine the skill, patience, and dedication required to create such a detailed work of art at a time when there were no modern machines or electric tools.

Look at the golden decorations, the carefully carved figures, and the many small details. The altarpiece is approximately 12 metres tall, reaching high into the cathedral's interior.

But this is not simply a beautiful decoration. Every figure and scene has a religious meaning."

"Now, let us look at the central section.

In the main part, we can see Saint Anne holding the Virgin Mary, who is associated with the infant Jesus. This composition is traditionally called Saint Anne Selvtredje, meaning Saint Anne with Mary and Jesus.

On one side stands Saint Clement, the patron saint of Aarhus Cathedral and traditionally associated with sailors. On the other side is Saint John the Baptist.

The twelve apostles appear on the side panels, each represented with identifying attributes or symbols.

These figures were important to Christian worship in the Middle Ages. They reminded the congregation of the people associated with the life of Jesus and the early Christian Church."

The golden details and the upper section

"Please look towards the upper part of the altarpiece.

Here, we can see the Coronation of the Virgin Mary, surrounded by the archangels Gabriel and Michael. Gabriel is associated with the announcement of good news, while Michael is traditionally depicted as a defender against evil, sometimes shown defeating a dragon.

Notice how the sculpted figures, golden surfaces, and decorative elements work together. The use of gold gives the altarpiece a luminous appearance, especially when light enters the cathedral.

The figures were carved, painted, and gilded, using gold of approximately 23.5 carats. Imagine how impressive this work must have appeared to people seeing it for the first time in the fifteenth century."

A fascinating detail: The altarpiece changes throughout the year

"Here is something particularly interesting: this altarpiece was designed to open and close.

It has five folding sections that reveal different sets of images during different parts of the Christian calendar.

During most of the year, the richly decorated feast-day side is displayed. During Lent, the panels are changed to reveal scenes from the Passion of Christ, depicting events leading to his crucifixion and resurrection. During Advent, another set of painted scenes is shown, including stories associated with Saint John the Baptist and the martyrdom of Saint Clement.

So, in the past, visitors would not necessarily have seen the same altarpiece throughout the year. Its appearance changed with the religious season, helping people follow the major events of the Christian calendar."

"The altarpiece was donated by Bishop Jens Iversen Lange, who played an important role in the development of Aarhus Cathedral during the fifteenth century.

The bishop is also represented in the artwork, including in a depiction of him kneeling in prayer.

This gives us an interesting connection between art, religion, and the people who financed important buildings and artworks during the Middle Ages.

The altarpiece was carefully restored between 1975 and 1981. During restoration, conservators removed old layers of varnish and uncovered details that had become difficult to see over time.

This work helped reveal more of the original colours and decorative details."

The Marselis Chapel (Marseliskapellet) : *This chapel was established by Sophie Elisabeth Carisius in memory of her first husband, Baron Constantin Marselis, who died in 1699. She purchased this chapel in 1702 and commissioned the sculptor Thomas Quellinus to create this remarkable memorial."*

"Ladies and gentlemen, as we stand here inside Aarhus Cathedral, let me introduce you to a family whose name has remained part of Danish history for more than three centuries: the Marselis family.

Interestingly, the Marselis family did not originally come from Denmark. They came from the Netherlands, and their story became connected with Aarhus during the seventeenth century.

At that time, Denmark's King Frederik III was facing financial difficulties. In 1661, the king transferred substantial Crown lands in Jutland to the wealthy Dutch merchant Gabriel Marselis, as part of settling royal debts.

Gabriel's sons, Constantin and Vilhelm, later became established in the Aarhus region. Constantin eventually became a baron, and the estate called Havreballegård was renamed Marselisborg.



Now, please look at this beautiful memorial in the Marselis Chapel. It connects us directly with the family's story. This monument was commissioned by Sophie Elisabeth Carisius, Constantin's widow, and commemorates her family relationships through impressive Baroque sculpture.

But the Marselis family's legacy did not remain only inside this cathedral.

If you visit the southern part of Aarhus, you will find Marselisborg Palace, the royal residence completed in 1902. You will also find the beautiful Marselisborg Forests, where people walk, cycle, and enjoy nature. The family owned several estates around Aarhus, including Marselisborg, Constantinsborg and Vilhelmsborg.



The All Souls Picture (Alle Sjæle-billedet)

The All Souls Picture is a remarkable medieval fresco in Aarhus Cathedral, dating from around 1500. It illustrates the medieval Christian understanding of the relationship between Heaven, Earth, and Purgatory. The painting was associated with an altar where Masses were offered for deceased people.

The fresco is divided into three main levels.

Upper level — Heaven

At the top, God the Father, Christ the Son, and the Holy Spirit are shown surrounded by angels making music. This represents the divine realm and the ultimate destination of the faithful.

Middle level — Earth and the Mass

The central scene depicts Pope Gregory's Mass. According to the medieval Christian tradition represented here, the bread and wine of the Eucharist become the body and blood of Christ. The Mass is presented as having spiritual significance for the souls of the dead.

Lower level — Purgatory

At the bottom, souls suffer in Purgatory while angels descend to rescue them and carry them upwards towards Heaven. This illustrates the belief that the dead could be helped by prayers and Masses offered by the living.

This brings us to a very interesting historical detail.

People could pay the Church to arrange Masses for their deceased relatives, believing that these prayers could help shorten the souls' time in Purgatory. This painting helped communicate the spiritual importance that people attached to those practices.

However, the practice of paying for religious services and indulgences became increasingly controversial. Criticism of abuses associated with indulgences became one of the issues that contributed to the Protestant Reformation in the sixteenth century.

So, this painting is not only a religious artwork. It also provides a window into the beliefs, fears, hopes, and religious practices of medieval society.



“Ladies and gentlemen, please direct your attention to this fascinating medieval fresco, painted in the year 1497.

The scene tells the legendary story of Saint George and the Dragon, one of the most popular Christian stories in medieval Europe.

Let us imagine that we are travelling back more than 500 years, to a time when religious stories were communicated not only through sermons and books, but also through paintings on the walls of churches.

Look at the centre of the painting. We see Saint George riding a beautiful white horse, holding a lance and attacking a huge dragon. He is the brave knight who confronts a terrible threat to protect the innocent.

Now, look to the side. We see a princess kneeling with a small white lamb. In the background, her parents watch anxiously from the castle. Imagine their fear as they witness this dangerous battle.

But here is the most interesting detail.

Please look carefully at the cave behind the large dragon. Can you see the smaller dragons hiding there?

The artist has included the dragon's young for a reason. In the cathedral's interpretation, they symbolise the continuing regeneration of evil. Even when the larger dragon is defeated, its young remain.

This gives the painting a deeper meaning. The struggle against evil is not necessarily finished with one victory. New threats may emerge, and the struggle must continue.

In medieval Christian symbolism, the dragon represents evil, while Saint George represents the Christian faith confronting that evil. The princess and her white lamb provide a contrast of innocence against danger.

Notice, too, the date 1497. This painting was created at a time when Aarhus Cathedral was being transformed into the magnificent Gothic church we see today.

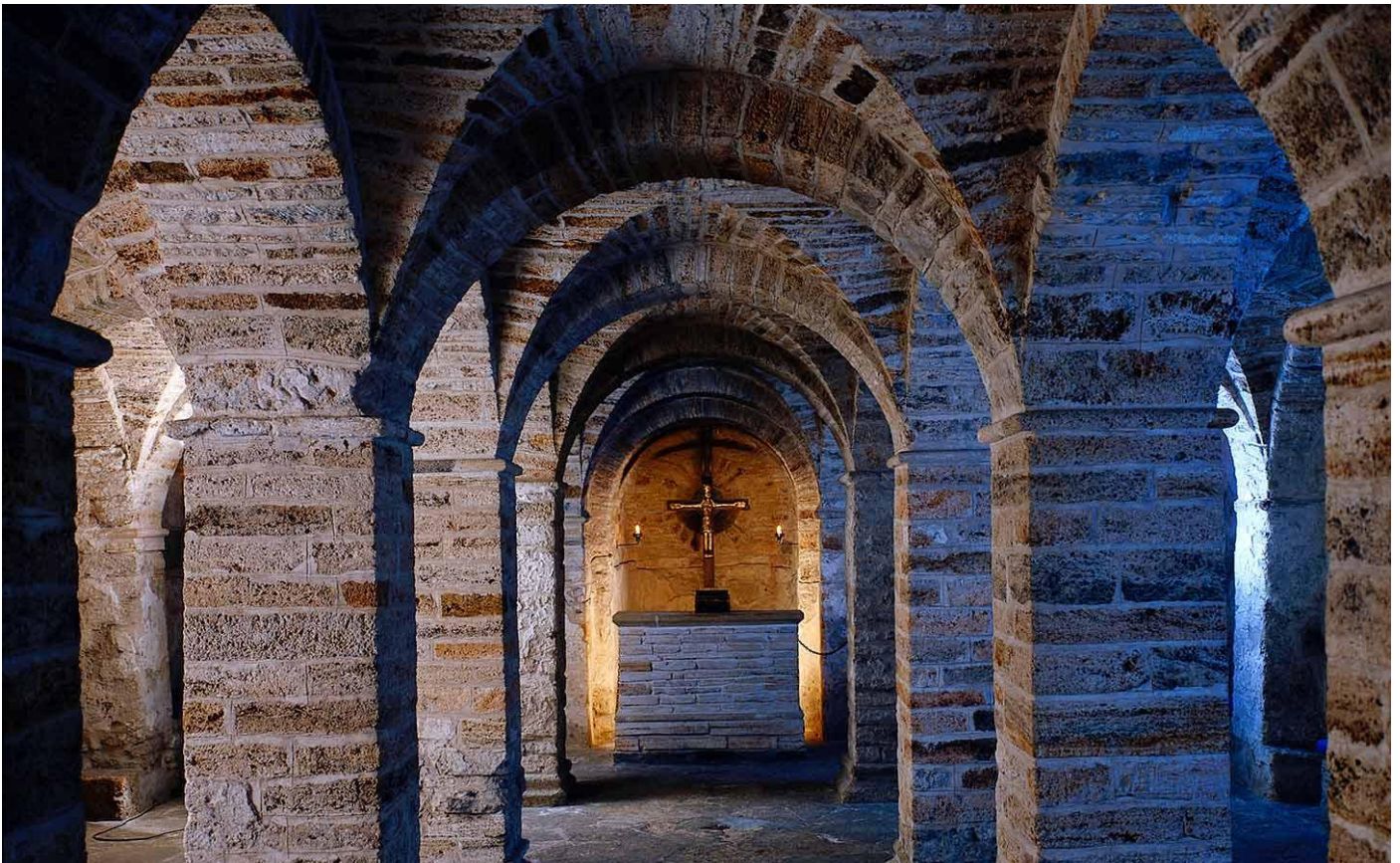
Stop 2: Our Lady Church — Vor Frue Kirke

“Ladies and gentlemen, welcome to our next stop: Our Lady Church, known in Danish as Vor Frue Kirke.

We are now standing in front of one of the historically significant churches in Aarhus. While Aarhus Cathedral is the city's great cathedral and a symbol of its religious importance, Our Lady Church tells us another part of the story — the story of the early Christian community, medieval religious life, and the development of the city itself.

Christianity was becoming more firmly established in Denmark, and churches were important signs of this transformation. Around 1060, a stone church was built here, dedicated to Saint Nicholas, the patron saint traditionally associated with sailors and seafarers.

The most extraordinary discovery — The hidden crypt church



Now we come to what I consider one of the most remarkable parts of our visit.

Beneath the floor of the church lies an older church — the Crypt Church, dating to around 1060.

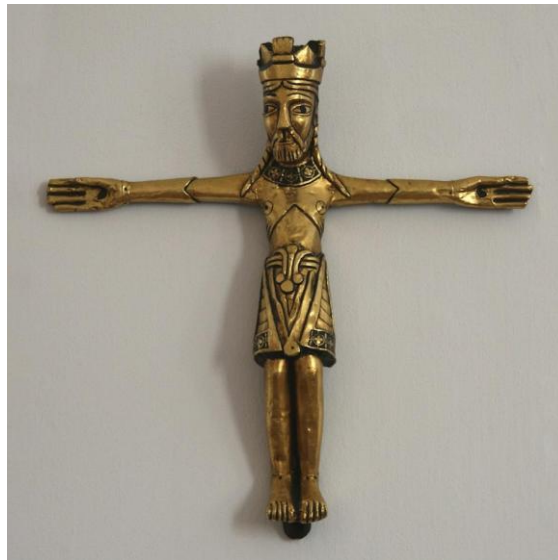
The word crypt often makes people think of a dark underground burial chamber. In this case, however, the space was designed as a place of worship. It was an actual church, with its own architectural structure and religious purpose.

The crypt has three aisles and three apses — the rounded or curved spaces traditionally found at the eastern end of a church. The three-part design was associated with the Christian Trinity: the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. The three apses each had an altar.

Then, during extensive restoration work in 1955, workers discovered the old crypt beneath the church floor. What had been hidden for generations was suddenly brought back into view.

The discovery was significant because it revealed a surviving part of Aarhus's earliest stone church and provided a rare opportunity to study early medieval church architecture in Denmark. The crypt was subsequently restored, and the room we can visit today preserves the layout of that earlier church.

The Åby Crucifix — A link between Viking culture and Christianity



“Here, we have another interesting connection between Denmark's Viking past and its Christian Middle Ages.

The crucifix displayed in the crypt is a copy of the Åby Crucifix. The original dates approximately to the period between 1050 and 1100 and was found in Åby Church, near Aarhus. Today, the original is kept at the National Museum of Denmark. Look closely at the figure of Christ.

In this Scandinavian Romanesque tradition, Christ is represented not simply as a suffering victim, but as a powerful, king-like figure. His clothing, moustache, and overall appearance have sometimes been compared with Viking-era visual traditions.

When this object was created, Denmark was undergoing a major religious transformation. Norse religious traditions had shaped Scandinavian society for generations, but Christianity was becoming increasingly established.

The transition did not happen overnight. It unfolded over time through contact with Christian Europe, royal influence, missionary activity, trade, and changing political relationships.

The interesting thing about this crucifix is that it belongs to a period when Christian beliefs were being expressed through Scandinavian artistic traditions.

Some features of the figure, including its appearance and styling, can remind modern viewers of Viking Age visual culture. The comparison helps us understand that the arrival of Christianity did not mean that every older artistic tradition immediately disappeared.

Instead, artists adapted familiar forms to express new religious ideas.

Stop 3: The Viking Museum — Discovering Viking-Age Aros

We have explored medieval Christianity and discovered a church hidden beneath another church. Now, we are going to travel even further back in time to discover the world of the Vikings.

When you hear the word 'Viking,' what is the first thing that comes to your mind?

Perhaps you imagine ships, warriors, swords, or people travelling across the sea?



"Ladies and gentlemen, please take a moment to look at this map.

At first glance, you might think we are looking at an ordinary street map of Aarhus. We can see familiar names such as Store Torv, Lille Torv, the cathedral, and the streets leading towards the harbour.

But this map tells us a much bigger story. It helps us imagine how Aarhus developed from a Viking settlement into the modern Danish city we know today.

The fascinating thing is that the Viking town was not located somewhere completely separate from the modern city. Its history is closely connected to the very centre where we are standing today.

"Let us begin with the name of the city. During the Viking Age, Aarhus was called Aros. The name is connected to the river mouth — the place where the Aarhus River meets the sea. This geographical position was one of the main reasons a settlement developed here.

Look at the lower part of the map, where we see the river marked as Aarhus Å. Imagine that the landscape around the river was much less built up than it is today.

Why would Vikings choose this location?

First, the river offered access between the sea and the inland countryside. Boats could bring goods and people towards the settlement, while routes along the river valley connected the town with the surrounding region.

Second, the coast provided access to maritime trade. Ships could travel between settlements around the Danish islands, the Scandinavian coast, and other parts of northern Europe.

Third, the river and its surrounding landscape created a useful crossing point. At a place where people and goods naturally came together, a settlement could grow.

Think of Aros as a meeting point between two worlds: the sea and the land.

A merchant arriving by boat might bring metal goods, pottery, or other products. Someone from the countryside might arrive with food, livestock, or materials for building. Craftspeople could produce goods for local use or exchange them with visiting traders.

We should not imagine every Viking as a warrior travelling across the sea. Many people were farmers, craftspeople, merchants, fishermen, and families trying to make a living.

The name Aros tells us that the river was not just a geographical feature. It was part of the reason the city came into existence.”

“Now, let us look at the central area of the map.

You can see Store Torv, which means ‘Large Square’, and nearby Lille Torv, or ‘Small Square’. You can also see Aarhus Cathedral, marked Århus Domkirke.

Today, these places are part of the busy city centre. People meet friends here, go shopping, visit cafés, and explore the historic streets.

But the centre of the modern city overlaps with the area where medieval Aarhus developed, including the earlier Viking settlement.

Archaeological discoveries have shown that the Viking town included houses, workshops, streets, and defensive structures. The Viking Museum is located beneath the modern city centre, on Store Torv, where remains of the old settlement were excavated.

It is important to remember that the modern map is a guide, not an exact picture of the Viking town. The streets and buildings have changed over many centuries. However, the map helps us understand the location of the early settlement in relation to the modern city.”

The ring rampart — Why was the town surrounded by a wall?

“Now I would like you to notice something very important: the curved line surrounding the historic centre.

This represents the area associated with the town's old defensive rampart.

During the 10th century, Aros was fortified with an earthen rampart. It was strengthened during the Viking Age, including during the reign of Harald Bluetooth, who ruled Denmark in the second half of the 10th century. The rampart formed an important part of the town's defences.

But why would a trading town need a defensive wall?

Imagine living here more than a thousand years ago. There was no modern police force, no permanent emergency service, and no organised system of national defence in the way we know it today.

A settlement could be threatened by rival groups, raiders, or competing political powers. A defensive rampart offered protection and made it easier to control who entered and left the town.

The rampart was also a practical statement: this was an organised settlement worth protecting.

Building and maintaining such a structure required planning and labour. It tells us that Aros was more than a collection of isolated houses. It had a degree of organisation and importance within the wider region.

Notice, too, how the defensive line relates to the natural landscape. Watercourses and low-lying ground could help make a settlement more difficult to approach. The combination of natural features and constructed defences was useful in an age when geography played a major role in protection.

Today, the old rampart is not visible as a complete wall around the city. Modern buildings and streets have transformed the area. Archaeological excavations, however, have revealed evidence of the fortification at several locations.

So when we walk through the centre of Aarhus, we are walking through an area that once had a very different character: a compact settlement enclosed by defences.”

Immervad — Where people crossed the river

“Here is a street name that offers us a particularly interesting clue: Immervad.

The name refers to an old ford — a shallow place where people could cross a river or stream on foot, sometimes with animals or goods.

Before modern bridges and roads, crossing a river was an important practical problem. People needed places where the water was shallow enough and the ground suitable for crossing.

A ford could become a natural meeting point. Travellers from different directions would arrive at the same location. Goods would move through the area, and people would exchange information as well as products.

Think about the kinds of journeys that might have passed through here. A farmer could bring food to town. A craftsperson might carry tools or materials. A merchant could be travelling between the harbour and an inland destination.

The location of a crossing could influence where streets developed and where people chose to settle.

The old crossing helps explain why this part of Aarhus became important for movement between the coast and the inland region. The modern street name preserves a memory of the landscape and travel patterns that existed long before today's traffic.

I like to use this as a reminder that place names are sometimes like small historical clues. Even when the original landscape has changed, a name can preserve an idea about how people once used the land.”

The harbour — Aarhus looking out towards the world

“Now let us turn our attention towards the sea.

On the right-hand side of the map, you can see Aarhus Havn, which means Aarhus Harbour.

Today, the harbour is associated with modern shipping, ferries, waterfront development, and large port facilities. In the Viking Age, the scale and appearance would have been completely different.

Instead of modern quays and industrial buildings, imagine wooden boats and ships, landing places, and people unloading goods by hand.

The sea connected Aros to other communities. It was a route for trade, travel, communication, and sometimes conflict.

The Viking Age was a period of extensive movement around the North Sea and Baltic Sea regions. People travelled for many reasons: trading, farming, migration, exploration, political alliances, and warfare.

Aros's location offered access to these networks. Its river connected the settlement with the surrounding land, while the sea connected it with other coastal communities.

We should remember that trade in the Viking Age did not necessarily involve enormous ships arriving every day. It could also mean small-scale exchanges, seasonal journeys, and local products moving between communities.

A town needed people to supply food, repair boats, make tools, produce textiles, and provide other essential services. Trade depended on this everyday work.

So, when you picture the Viking harbour, imagine more than ships. Picture the people who made maritime life possible: the boat builders, merchants, craftspeople, sailors, and families whose lives were connected to the water.

Aros was a small town, but its location connected it to a much wider world.”

That is what makes Aarhus so interesting: beneath the modern city lies the story of the people who built the settlement more than a thousand years ago.

The name Aros, the old river crossing, the defensive rampart, the harbour, and the cathedral all help us understand how this place developed.

So, the next time you walk through the streets of Aarhus, try to imagine the layers of history beneath your feet.

You are not simply walking through a modern Danish city. You are walking through a landscape shaped by generations of people, from the Viking Age to the present day.

The Viking pit-house — A home and a workshop



This type of building is called a pit-house. In Danish, it is known as grubehuset. As the name suggests, part of the building was dug into the ground. This helped create a sheltered space for people to live and work.

Notice the wooden walls and the steep thatched roof. The materials are simple, but the construction reflects practical knowledge developed through generations.

Why build a house partly underground? The sunken floor helped create a protected working and living space. The roof provided shelter from rain, wind, and cold, while the timber framework supported the structure.

But here is something interesting: this was not necessarily just a home. According to the museum's explanation, pit-houses could be used both as workshops and as dwellings.

Imagine a craftsperson spending the day here making or repairing things, then using the same sheltered space for other domestic activities.

Look through the entrance. Can you imagine the smell of wood, smoke, wool, and damp earth? The sound of tools being used? The light entering through the doorway while someone works inside?

Viking Age life was not only about sailing and warfare. Most people also needed to make clothes, prepare food, repair tools, and produce everyday household objects.

The Rune Stone — From Norse Beliefs to Christianity



"Ladies and gentlemen, please come a little closer and look at this large stone.

At first glance, it might look like an ordinary piece of rock, but it is actually a message from more than a thousand years ago. It is what we call a runestone.

Before people in Denmark commonly used the alphabet we use today, they wrote using a system of characters called runes. These characters were used by Scandinavian people during the Viking Age and earlier periods.

Look carefully at the surface. Can you see the lines and symbols carved into the stone? These are not random scratches. They were deliberately made to communicate a message.

Imagine the work involved. A person had to choose the stone, plan the inscription, and carve the characters into a hard surface using tools. This required time, skill, and effort.

Unlike a message written on paper, a runestone was intended to last. It could stand outdoors and be seen by people passing by. In this way, the stone became a permanent reminder of a person, a family, or an important event.

So a runestone was not necessarily just a gravestone. It could be a memorial, a public declaration, and a lasting record of family relationships.

The large Jelling Stone, raised by King Harald Bluetooth in the 10th century, is a famous example. Its inscription connects Harald with the unification of Denmark and his claim to have made the Danes Christian.

The tradition of raising runestones spread beyond the royal elite to other members of society.

The Norse gods — Understanding Viking beliefs



De nordiske guder

The Nordic gods

I den nordiske mytologi er der et væld af guder, der har forskellige egenskaber, og som der er knyttet forskellige historier til.

In Nordic mythology there is an abundance of gods, each with their own properties and about whom various stories are told.



Frey, Freyja og Njord

Njord er tilknyttet havet og får til bølgerne Frey og Freyja. Frey er frugtbarhedsuden, som sørger for god høst. Hans søster Freyja er knyttet til kærlighed og sex, og sammen med Odin kører Frigg (Balders hustru) i karvender med lodder. Freyja kører i en karve drevet af to katte, og når Frigg rider til kamp, rider hun de lodder med Odin.

Njord, Freyja og Frey er af verdens slægt. Myterne fortæller at verdens var lang med jærrens slægt, som Odin og de fleste andre guder tilhører. Da der blev skabt jord, gik slægterne forvædet på hin. Det var Njord, Frey og Freyja, der blev udvalgt til jærrens.



Thor

Thor er tordensuden og den stærkeste af guderne. Thor beskytter guderne mod jærrens med sin hammer Mjølner.

De mange mennesker i Norden, Nord og vest, Thor beskytter, for eksempel forvædet Thorvæden, at de mange land af mennesker formet som Thor. Thorvæden viser, at Thor var en populær gud i vikingetiden. Ligeledes Odin var Thor en gud, der kunne beskytte og sikre velfærdigheden. Thor Odin synes at have været gud for de uvalgte, var Thor i høje og gud og lod jærrens.

Thursday betyder Thor's dag.



Odin og Frigg

Odin er krigens og korpens gud. Han har hunden Valhalla, hviler han over guderne land Andel. Odin har givet et øre øre for at driske af verdens træer. Odin og Frigg er knyttet til kærlighed og sex, og sammen med Odin kører Frigg (Balders hustru) i karvender med lodder. Freyja kører i en karve drevet af to katte, og når Frigg rider til kamp, rider hun de lodder med Odin.

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Loke

Loke er en jærre, men han er færdig med Odin og lever sammen med guderne. Loke blev skabt som gudsuden, men er en figur i den nordiske mytologi, der har den funktion, at han får ting til at ske.

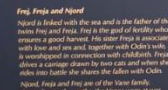
Han er mor af Odin, han slægt og får til Fenslægt, der blev den til og Midgården, der ligger rundt om menneskenes land, Midgården. Han har skabt guderne Thor, Mjølner, og Odin og Odin. Han har givet alle hans midde, at guderne vinder over jærrens, men med Ragnarok kommer han på jærrens side mod guderne.



Tyr

Guden Tyr er knyttet til lapper og korp. Han driske en øre, for at guderne kunne vinde over jærrens forvædet, der var spillet af at driske Odin og Ragnarok, guderne vinder.

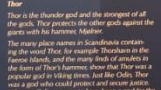
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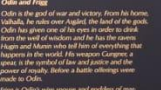


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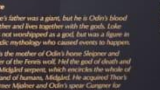


Odin og Frigg

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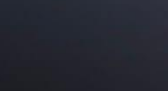
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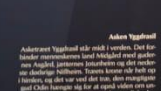
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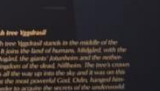


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“Now let us move from everyday work to the spiritual world of the Vikings.

This exhibition introduces us to the gods of Norse mythology. Before Christianity became established in Denmark, people worshipped a variety of Norse gods and goddesses. These figures were associated with different aspects of life, nature, power, wisdom, fertility, and conflict.

Let me introduce you to some of the most famous figures.

Frey, Freyja, and Njord

Frey, also known as Freyr, was associated with fertility, prosperity, peace, and good harvests.

Freyja was associated with love, fertility, beauty, and a form of magic known as seiðr. She also had connections with battle and the dead.

Njord was associated with the sea, seafaring, wealth, and favourable winds.

Think about how important these themes were to people living in Viking Age Aarhus. A good harvest meant food for the family. The sea provided opportunities for fishing and trade, but it could also be dangerous. Prosperity and favourable conditions were matters of everyday concern.

These gods connected religious belief with the practical realities of life.

Thor — The god of thunder

Thor is one of the most recognisable figures in Norse mythology.

He was associated with thunder, strength, protection, and the defence of the gods and human world against dangerous forces. His famous hammer was called Mjölnir.

The hammer became an important symbol in Viking Age Scandinavia. Archaeologists have discovered pendants shaped like Thor's hammer, suggesting that some people wore them as expressions of religious identity or protection.

Imagine being a farmer facing a violent storm or a traveller worried about danger on a journey. Thor represented strength and protection in a world where people had limited control over nature.

Odin and Frigg

Odin was associated with wisdom, war, poetry, magic, and the pursuit of knowledge. He is often portrayed as a complex figure who seeks wisdom even at great personal cost.

Frigg, associated with marriage, family, and the household, was one of the most important goddesses in Norse mythology.

Their stories reflect a world in which knowledge, family, fate, and conflict were closely connected.

Loki

Loki is a complicated character. He is associated with cleverness, trickery, disruption, and transformation. In some stories, he helps the gods; in others, his actions create serious problems.

He is not simply a straightforward villain. His role varies across the myths, and his stories often explore the consequences of cleverness, pride, and unpredictable behaviour.

Tyr

Tyr is associated with courage, law, duty, and sacrifice. One famous story tells how he placed his hand in the mouth of the wolf Fenrir while the gods attempted to bind the dangerous creature. When Fenrir realised he had been deceived, he bit off Tyr's hand.

The story connects Tyr with bravery and the willingness to accept personal risk for the wider community.

The language has changed. Religious beliefs have changed. The settlement of Aros has grown into the modern city of Aarhus. Yet the stone remains.

It connects us directly with the people who lived here during the Viking Age. Through its runes and its Christian cross, it also gives us a glimpse of a society in transition.

Thank you, everyone. Let us continue exploring the history of Viking Age Aarhus."

